

Are we there yet?

This month the entire digit team seemed to have caught the sci-fi bug and I was no exception. In preparation for our collaborative writing experiment, our collective knowledge of science fiction tropes was being poured into a smelting pot in the hope of coming up with possible story angles and directions for our little sci-fi adventure on page 62.

Almost always though, a natural consequence of any deliberation on this topic brings to mind the infinitesimally small place we occupy in this universe. Just listen to Carl Sagan's pale blue dot audio clip and one can't help but be humbled by how truly small our lives, achievements and problems are in the grander scheme of things. That being said, nothing can stop our infinite curiosity to know more about the physical universe – and that's precisely where science and science fiction stem from.

Leading scientists the world over are currently working hard to come up with a unified theory of everything – the sort of holy grail of scientific study and the elusive answer to “life, the universe and everything”. Of course we are far from that stage yet, but there are a few things most scientists do agree on. For one thing, everything in the known universe (multiverses aside) can be studied and understood by analysing matter and energy and the way these two interact with each other in time and space. Sure, new laws of physics will be discovered and new particles will be unearthed but the fundamentals will remain the same. The tools for expanding our understanding of the universe are right there in front of us.

Or are they?

This is where most discussions of this nature set the stage for the entry of spirituality – the idea that there is a missing piece of the puzzle, a fundamental requirement for us to know the answers to everything; the G word. Now I won't call myself an atheist or agnostic, but certainly as a rationalist, these sort of wishy-washy ideals are to me – for the lack of a better word – sacrilege, when mixed with scientific inquiry.

But as it turns out, minds far greater than mine believe that there could be more to the universe than just matter, energy and physical forces. Dr. Thomas Nagel, for instance, in his book *Mind and Cosmos* (which to be honest, I've only recently come to know of thanks to a NYT article) says that modern scientific theory has conspicuously failed to explain such central mind-related features of

our world as consciousness. It's true that while we can explain how the brain works to a great extent – neurons, electrical signals, chemical compositions et al., – no one has come close to explaining how thoughts are really produced. What is interesting is that Dr. Nagel is supposed to be an atheist and doesn't really believe in an omniscient creator. He does, however, believe that the mind – a biological organ capable of developing a science so intricate – should be considered a fundamental principle of nature along with matter and energy. Sounds like hippie mysticism? But who knows... Maybe the evolution of the mind was indeed teleological (for a purpose) rather than the simple result of a series of mutations over the eons. Maybe consciousness itself is the key to unlocking and comprehending the secrets of the universe. Look up the concept of panpsychism – it'll blow your mind – figuratively of course.

Coming a full circle back to science fiction, what is funny is all of this sounds eerily similar to a book I'd read ages ago called *Childhood's End* by Arthur C. Clarke. In it humanity is visited by an alien species with seemingly dubious intentions – friend or foe you can't tell till the end. Here's an excerpt from the original back cover quote: *Humans called them Overlords, and initially they brought peace and prosperity to Earth. But then the change began. It appeared first in the children – frightening, incomprehensible. Now the Overlords made their announcement: This was to be the first step in the elimination of the human race and the beginning of – What?*

The dramatisation aside, the book is centred around a theme of transcendent evolution as humanity makes its way towards its next step in evolution. A concept that scientists seem to be giving serious thought to in some way or the other.

Technologically we've come a long way since mankind first started putting pen to paper or charcoal to cave wall whatever you might call it. And this has happened in a mere blink of an eye compared to how long we've been on this earth. Will we find all the answers soon? Maybe not. Certainly not in my lifespan. But considering the progress we've made, I think we're getting there. 



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Got feedback about this column?
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